MCP

Title:

Power Struggle

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Characters:

The Air Controller, *a young superhero*
Muscle Mage, *a young superhero*

Setting:

The Secret Headquarters of the Legion of Heroic Guardians

Note: While the parts as written use female pronouns, the characters are not tied to a single gender and permission is given to make adjustments as needed.

The Air Controller (AC): Thank you all for this opportunity to try out for the Legion of Heroic Guardians, the greatest organization of superheroes in the known galaxy! It's been my dream since I was a child to use my powers and abilities to preserve justice and protect those in need! As I look around me and see legendary heroes like The Purple Bee, Gladiator Prime, Aviatrix, Dr. Cyclone, and so many more, I am honored to be considered for membership alongside those caped crusaders I have admired for so long. I believe that, once you see me in action, you'll–

Muscle Mage (MM): (*running up, slightly out of breath*) Sorry! So sorry I'm late. I know I was scheduled for 2:30, but there was–

AC: Hey, wait your turn, okay? This is my audition slot! Members of the Legion of Heroic Guardians, today I will demonstrate–

MM: Um, look, you need to cut me a little slack. While you were here rehearsing your speech, I was out foiling a plot by Dr. Despicable and his Evil Robot Septuplets!

AC: I don't care where you were or what you were doing. You missed your scheduled audition, and this is my time block. So, just come back next year, okay?

MM: I most certainly will not! I was invited here, too! I have just as much right as you have to audition for the Legion of Heroic Guardians.

AC: You DID have as much right as I have, but you missed your audition. So…bye!

MM: But as I said, I had a really good reason. I was putting others first, like a good superhero should.

AC: Well, I think a big part of being a good superhero is, you know, showing up in a timely manner.

MM: Well, I think part of being a good superhero is not being a pompous little–

AC: (*cutting her off; to the superhero committee*) Ladies and gentlemen, as I was saying–

MM: (*also to the committee*) Thank you so much for the opportunity–

AC: –once you see me in action–

MM: –I know that I have what it takes to join–

AC: –you will realize that I will be the perfect choice to join–

AC, MM: –The Legion of Heroic Guardians!

MM: If the committee would just give me a moment to–

AC: Okay, I think that's about enough out of you!

> *(She gestures dramatically in the air, then continues talking to the committee. As soon as she finishes her gesture, Muscle Mage continues speaking, but no sound can be heard. Muscle Mage takes a step forward and rebounds as though striking a brick wall. She looks about quizzically and takes another step forward, with the same result. She enacts the "mime trapped in a box" routine, then begins yelling soundlessly and pounding on the invisible container surrounding her).*

I believe I have what it takes to be a useful member of the LHG and to help them fight their never-ending battle against injustice. I am–The Air Controller! My powers, as you can see, (*gesturing to Muscle Mage*) are a remarkable deterrent to crime. My absolute control over the molecules of the air allows me to harden them into a barrier stronger than steel. No evildoer can overcome my impenetrable air prisons! No physical force

known can break through them! In addition, I can use my air powers to help me fly or lift heavy objects.

(Inside the "box," Muscle Mage, seething with anger, raises her fingers to her temples, implying that she is using her superpower as well. Just as Air Controller gets to "lift heavy objects" and raises her arms to show her strength, she suddenly slaps herself in the face).

I'm–I'm sorry, I don't know what came over me, I–

(Air Controller slaps herself again, this time with the opposite hand).

I'm not sure what is happening here.

(Muscle Mage has a huge smile on her face. Air Controller realizes what is happening).

You're–

(another slap)

–doing this–

(another slap)

–aren't you?

(another slap)

Really mature. That's really mature.

(Suddenly, her hand points two fingers in a "peace" sign. She looks perplexed for a minute–and then the two fingers start moving toward her eyes. With her other hand, she grabs her own arm, fighting to prevent the arm under Muscle Mage's control from poking herself in the eyes).

Okay, fine, if that's how you want to play it.

(She thrusts her possessed hand away with great effort and a groan, then claps both hands together in front of her. As she does so, Muscle Mage's hands drop from her temples to her cheeks, squishing her lips into a "duck face." At the same time, her whole body compresses to simulate the invisible air prison walls tightening on her).

My air prisons can subdue *any* foe, no matter *who* she is. Clearly, I am the better choice for membership in the Legion!

(Muscle Mage squints her eyes tightly closed, and suddenly Air Controller begins slapping and hitting herself in the face repeatedly, and so on, and then starts to choke herself with one hand while the other hand tries to prevent it from doing so. The "possessed" limb then pulls itself away, makes a fist in the air, then punches Air Controller in the gut. She doubles over and inhales loudly).

MM: (*begins "speaking" angrily during the "choking" portion but can only be heard when Air Controller is hit in the stomach*) –clearly the better choice and I have the powers to prove it! I, Muscle Mage, have the ability to control the muscles of any other individual with my mind–even so-called super-powered individuals like this one. I look forward to being a part of the Legion, and I am committed to–(*she stumbles forward, as though she's been kicked from behind*)

AC: (*breathing heavily*) Just–need a moment–to catch my breath…

MM: –I am committed to becoming a world-class–*(again, another impact from behind)*

AC: Oh, you're a world-class *something* all right! *(she has been using her air powers to strike Muscle Mage in the posterior; she does it again)*

MM: Would you cut that out!

AC: What's the matter? Can't handle a little competition?

(another air-bump from behind)

MM: Competition? You want competition? Fine! Let's have a dance-off!

(Air Controller's eyes grow large as she realizes what Muscle Mage means).

AC: Look, I just want to have my audition without–

MM: Oh, I'm going to give you an audition all right!

(Muscle Mage waves her hands wildly in the air. Air Controller, against her will, begins to dance in an awkward and embarrassing way, with wild, jerky movements).

AC: Really? You have the power to control other people's muscles and this is what you do with it? You're a lousy excuse for a superhero, you know that? This is really immature!

MM: I'm immature? You were the one using your super power over air molecules to kick me in the butt!

AC: That was your butt? I guess I got it confused with your face!

MM: Ooh, I know, let's see if you can do the Macarena!

AC: Come on! This is ridiculous!

(she begins doing the dance moves for the macarena)

MM: Just demonstrating who is the better superhero here, that's all! I think I've made my point to–

(she begins speaking, but again silently. She realizes slowly she's trapped again. Her hands mime a bubble shape around her head).

AC: *(still dancing the macarena)* I hope the committee will take note that even when my body is under the control of a malign influence, I can still use my superior abilities to encase an opponent's head in a solid bubble of air. And, once I've done that, my opponent is entirely at my mercy.

(While Air Controller speaks, Muscle Mage holds her hands around the invisible bubble. It suddenly "pulls" her backward a few steps, then forward a few. Then, the bubble seems to pull her head violently left and right, back and forth multiple times, then it seems to lift her off the ground as she stands on tip-toes, desperately pounding at the bubble).

AC: (continuing) But I'm not here to embarrass anyone.

(The "bubble" collapses, Muscle Mage strikes herself in the face, and then collapses to the ground. With this lapse in concentration, Air Controller can finally stop dancing).

AC: (continuing) I'm just here to demonstrate that my abilities are superior to…hers.

MM: I'll show you superior!

AC: Just you try it!

MM: I'm going to–

(They both stop talking at once)

AC: Um, is someone talking inside my head?

MM: You hear it too?

AC: Riiiight. Ms. Mental.

MM: She's telepathic.

(They listen to the unheard telepathic voice and react with dismay).

AC: But…Wait, that's not fair! I deserve to finish my audition!

MM: Please, let me have another chance! I know I can do this!

AC & MM: *(together)* Rejected!?!

(They listen again to the voice, reacting and ad libbing "Well, yes–" and "Sure, but–" to what is clearly pointed and accurate criticism).

AC: No, I understand. You're right–I should have been more welcoming to a fellow hero.

MM: Yes, I should have been less impulsive.

(Again, they react to the unheard telepathic voice).

AC: Do I have to?

MM: She started it.

AC: Really, this is all her fault.

MM: If she had been a little more open-minded, we–

AC: All she had to do was get here on time and–

MM: Oh, come on, she–

AC: She's really the one who–

(They react as though someone is screaming in their ears).

AC: Okay, fine fine fine! I get it!

MM: I hear you! Just…stop yelling in my head! Please!

(They sigh in unison).

AC: *(through gritted teeth)* Muscle Mage, I am sorry–deeply sorry–that I locked you in a cage of air molecules and kicked you in the rear end.

MM: *(equally reluctantly)* Air Controller, I regret that I made you punch yourself in the face repeatedly and dance the Macarena.

AC: So, uh….what happens now? Can I reapply next year?

MM: I promise I will keep working to become an even better superhero. I know I belong with the Legion of Heroic Guardians, and–

AC & MM: *(together)* What?

AC: You want the two of us to do what? Work with another hero?

AC: Wait, you mean–

MM: You want us to be–

AC & MM *(together, with disbelief)*: Sidekicks?

MM: I guess it sort of makes sense. I just thought I was ready to be a hero on my own, you know?.

AC: I suppose it is the next logical step. Sort of a mentorship program, right?

MM: *(thinking it over)* I bet I can be a great sidekick.

AC: Well, I will, naturally, be a better one.

MM: Perhaps you can learn to reign in that ego by working with a better hero.

AC: Working with a real superhero might help you learn to be on time.

MM: You miserable little–You know what? I'm not even going to argue. A year from now, it will be clear who the better sidekick is–me.

AC: I'm going to be a much better sidekick than you. *(to the voice)* So which Legion member do I get to work with? Purple Bee? Ocean Queen?

MM: How about me? Thunder Master? Sky Raider?

AC: Neon Tarantula?

MM: Elastic Lord?

AC: Dr. Gravity?

MM: Captain Cloud?

AC: Kinetic Kid?

MM: The Blue Ostrich?

AC and MM: *(simultaneously, with a sense of awe at the possibility)* Remarkable Man?

MM: Oh, please! If anyone is going to be partnered up with Remarkable Man, it's going to be me. My powers are a much better complement to his.

AC: Oh, right. You as a sidekick to Remarkable Man? Don't make me laugh. You wouldn't even be a decent sidekick to the Yellow Condor, because–

MM and AC *(together)*: Ow ow ow!

MM: Again with the yelling!

AC: Are all telepaths this loud?

> *(They listen again to the instructions from the telepathic voice, their faces etched with confusion and ad libbing sounds of uncertainty).*

MM: Okay, I'm a little confused here. You're saying you want us to work with another hero, but NOT a hero who's a member of the Legion.

AC: That doesn't make any sense. I mean, I don't really want to be a sidekick to some nobody–

MM: Oh. So, not so much a sidekick?

AC: More of a partner thing, then?

MM: Like, Simon & Garfunkel?

AC: Hall & Oates?

MM: Sacco & Vanzetti?

AC: So, I would partner with an up-and-coming hero?

MM: Like, team up and help each other?

AC: Someone on my level.

MM: Someone who needs my assistance.

AC: Helping another hero become more…organized.

MM: Providing another hero with a bit of…spark.

AC: I can do that.

MM: No problem.

AC: Sign me up!

MM: I am a team player.

AC: I am a better team player.

MM: Do you even listen to yourself?

AC: Okay, fine. The important thing is, we both get paired up with someone who will help us improve, so next year, I can join the Legion.

MM: You mean so I can join the Legion.

AC: So the better superhero can join the Legion.

MM: Who am I going to be paired up with?

AC: A better question: What up-and-coming superhero gets to work with me?

(they react to the telepathic voice)

MM: Not her!

AC: Not her!

MM: No way could I work with her.

AC: She is clearly not partner material.

MM: I'd rather have my powers stripped away by a supervillain!

AC: A month teaming up with her would turn me *into* a supervillain!

MM: We couldn't even get along during this tryout!

AC: I can't believe you think we could work together to fight crime!

MM: She's self-centered, unfeeling, and bossy!

AC: She's immature, disorganized, and rude!

MM: Are you sure we can't do something else?

AC: Are there any other options?

(The silent voice responds. They listen with frustration and, eventually, resignation).

MM: Yeah, that's what I was afraid of. Fine. I will be the best partner to Air Controller I can.

AC: And I will be an even *better* partner to Muscle Mage.

MM: And in a year, we'll be back to re-apply. And you will be amazed at the exploits of… Muscle Mage and Air Controller

AC: I believe you mean Air Controller and Muscle Mage.

MM: Based on what? Alphabetical order?

AC: No, based on birth order!

MM: That again?

AC: Well, why not?

MM: You are only eight minutes older than I am!

AC: It's not my fault that even when we were born you were late!

MM: You know what? Fine. Have it your way. "Air Controller and Muscle Mage" it is. But when we get home, you're explaining this whole thing to mom and dad!